



Source: YCharts.

*Fortune* chose Cisco over Microsoft and GE, and it did the poorest of the three. Microsoft has demolished all comers, gaining nearly 600%. GE is down nearly 30% since then, but way ahead of Cisco.

Since that 2000 cover story, the S&P 500 is up over 300%, the Nasdaq 100 gained more than 500%, and Cisco is still 20% below where it was on that date 25 years ago. It is even more remarkable that the Nasdaq 100 is up that much despite the drag its once biggest component—Cisco—had on the index's returns.

It is a stark reminder: When it comes to stock picking or predicting the future, nobody knows anything. Or to be more precise, a tiny handful of outliers have proven themselves to be consistent stock pickers over time (more on them later), but you can be sure they aren't writing cover stories for magazines.

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I have no beef with any one stock pick, but rather, the way the media constantly makes these grand pronouncements.